

like long distance runners in an industry that is traditionally been quite cruel to women. Kangana has carved a niche for herself playing angst-ridden characters in movies such as Anurag Basu's *Gangster* and *Life...in a Metro*. She is not the archetypal glam girl who is content to look vapid, and will soon be seen as Hrithik Roshan's rich chick in Basu's *Kites*, though she is also undergoing some laughter therapy with Anees Bazmee's new film, *No Problem*. She trained with the Asmita Theatre Group under eminent theatre director Arvind Gaur in Delhi, and even tried her hand at modelling, before moving to Mumbai to make it in the movies. Sonam, having starred in two films where she shone despite box office failure, Sanjay Leela Bhansali's *Saawariya* and Mehra's *Delhi-6*, is now also co-producing (with sister Rhea) the Indian adaptation of Jane Austen's *Emma*, *Aisha*, directed by Rajshree Ojha, with Abhay Deol playing her Philip Knightley. That is when she is not busy being fashionista about town or reading the latest Murakami. Asin, already a big star in the South, wafted across the blood soaked screen of *Ghajini* like a breath of fresh air. She's been

careful about signing on in a rush, being busy with endorsements that take her across the country, and will now be seen almost a year later in Vipul Shah's *London Dreams* as a Tamil girl who has a dual identity. And Genelia D'Souza, again a big star down South, and currently shepherding posh Mumbaikars through the travails of living in a slum, in UTV Bindass' *Big Switch*, has tried hard to capitalise on the surprise success of the bouncy *Jaane Tu...Ya Jaane Na*. She's been seen in some forgettable Hindi movies since then, but her Telugu film career continues at breakneck speed, which may explain why she has been picked as the face of both Fanta and Perk. All the young women, whether they've come from a life of Bollywood privilege like Sonam, or of gritty struggle like Kangana, have one thing in common—they are not content to be mere showpieces. They would like roles that flex their acting muscle, and they'd rather do a series of highly paid endorsements than an array of bad films. They're not in a hurry and seem quite willing to make haste slowly, choosing the right projects, being advised by the correct people, actor father Anil Kapoor in Sonam's case, and businessman dad JT in Asin's case. What's better is that they mean it when they say they prefer to be talked about for their work. ■

**Kangana
Ranaut, 22**

She speaks her mind and doesn't like clichés. She believes in quality work not quantity factory production.

**Genelia
D'Souza, 22**

A success in four different languages, she is perfect for Bollywood's perky comedies, but can do much more.